households to encompass all of these elements. While HDFC attempted to offer a whole range of products under one roof, it was keen to preserve the concept of specialized personnel for different functions and thus retain the benefit to be derived from comparative advantage.

The way business was done was changing rapidly. Much of this process was the consequence of new technologies that were being absorbed rapidly by businesses. Globalization and its consequences (of which the technological revolution has served as a great catalyst) enabled both information and capital to flow across frontiers instantaneously and at zero cost. Businesses were becoming more customer-friendly and instant gratification became the norm. In this scenario, it was up to HDFC to ‘own the information, set the standards and keep the customer’. Customers themselves were changing from loyal, limited information consumers, to choice driven, price and information sensitive customers. They demanded customization rather than standard sales, and completion of transactions rather than just their initiation. HDFC has met this challenge and is gearing up for many more.